

LINNAEUS'S TWO-TOED SLOTH

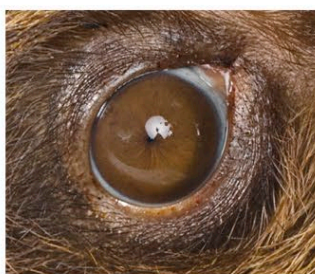
Choloepus hoffmanni

Small and arboreal, Linnaeus's two-toed sloth is far removed from its giant ground-dwelling ancestors, which only became extinct about 10,000 years ago. It is one of the slowest-moving mammals and sleeps for about 13 hours a day, often curled into a ball in the fork of a tree, waking at night to forage for leaves. The sloth's fur is unusual in supporting an ecosystem that includes unique micro-organisms, green algae, and various insects. In damp conditions, the coat may acquire a green hue due to the algae growing in the grooves of the hairs.

SIZE 54–88 cm (21½–35 in)
HABITAT Tropical lowland forest
DISTRIBUTION Orinoco and Amazon basins, S. America
DIET Mainly leaves

EYE >

The eyes are large and forward facing, but the eyesight is poor. Sloths are near-sighted, colour blind, and have poor visual acuity.



< TEETH

The five upper and four lower teeth are peg-like, lack enamel, and grow throughout life. There are no incisors.



NOSE >

A short snout with a large, snub nose at its tip provides the sloth with an excellent sense of smell.



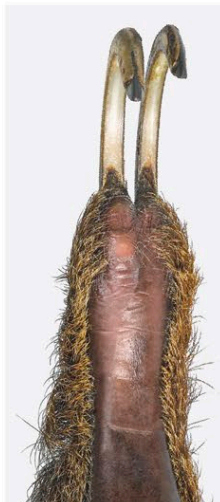
< EAR

The sloth's hearing is poor and limited to lower frequencies. The external part of the ear is tiny and buried in the fur.



CLAWS >>

The forelimb terminates in two digits, each with a 8–10 cm (3¼–4 in), hook-like claw. The hind limb has three clawed digits.



MIDDLE PARTING >

Due to their upside-down lifestyle, the fur parts in the midline of the chest and abdomen and falls down towards the back, so rain will run off.

